Ground Zero 2026
Official Problem Statements

GROUND ZERO

Loading From Zero,

A Groundbreaking Tomorrow.

Organised by NUS Entrepreneurship Society (NES)
Startup Development Division

NUS ENTREPRENEURSHIP SOCIETY

Welcome to Ground Zero 2026

Hey everyone, welcome to Ground Zero 2026.

Before you dive into the problem statements, here is what you need to know about how this year works.

We have gone broader. The four sectors we have put together, Data Tech, Finance, Health & Wellness, and Sustainability, are your playing field, but they are not walls. Think of them as directions, not destinations. The examples and opportunity spaces inside each sector are there to spark your thinking, not box it in. Some of the best ideas you will come up with probably sit at the intersection of two sectors, or take a familiar problem and attack it from a completely new angle. That is exactly what we want to see.

Your one non-negotiable: your idea needs to clearly belong somewhere. Pick the sector it fits best under and own that. If you genuinely feel like your idea breaks the mold and does not fit any of the four, we have got you covered. The Open Category exists precisely for that.

The sector landscapes we have put together are meant to give you context, where the world is heading, what is broken, and where the gaps are. Read them carefully. The best problem statements do not come from skimming. They come from sitting with the material, questioning what is missing, and thinking about who is actually being left behind by the solutions that already exist.

We are not looking for the most technical idea. We are not looking for the biggest idea. We are looking for the most meaningful one, something grounded in a real problem, backed by evidence, and built with a clear sense of who it is for.

Talk to people. Test your assumptions early. The teams that do the work upfront, the user interviews, the quick surveys, the honest conversation, are always the ones who show up with sharper, more compelling ideas on the day.

Alright. Here is your landscape for 2026. Read it, absorb it, and start asking questions.

Sector 01 - Data Tech

AI Infrastructure, Data Systems, and Cybersecurity

Data has become the backbone of modern economies. The rapid rise of artificial intelligence, cloud computing, and digital services has created unprecedented demand for scalable data infrastructure and secure digital systems.

A major driver of this transformation is the AI boom. Training large models requires enormous computational resources and specialised hardware such as GPUs and AI accelerators. This has led to explosive growth in data centres, cloud infrastructure, and high-performance computing systems, creating both opportunities and new infrastructure bottlenecks.

At the same time, these powerful technologies are creating entirely new security challenges. Modern AI systems are increasingly connected to external tools, applications, and data sources, which expands the potential attack surface. Researchers have found thousands of deployments exposed to the internet due to weak configurations, highlighting how quickly emerging technologies can introduce systemic vulnerabilities.

Enterprises are now grappling with issues such as shadow AI, where employees deploy AI tools without IT approval, creating governance and security risks. Meanwhile, vulnerabilities in AI infrastructure components such as databases, inference servers, and container toolkits are becoming common targets for cyber attackers.

Beyond security, organisations are also struggling with how to derive meaningful insights from vast amounts of data. Many companies have accumulated massive datasets but lack tools to turn them into actionable intelligence while maintaining transparency and accountability.

Global Examples

- NVIDIA - AI accelerators powering modern machine learning
- Snowflake - cloud-native data infrastructure
- Databricks - unified data and AI platforms
- CrowdStrike - AI-driven cybersecurity
- Palantir - large-scale data analytics for governments and enterprises

Singapore Start-Up Examples

- Manus AI - AI agents and infrastructure for enterprise automation
- Advance Intelligence Group - AI-powered data and credit decision systems
- Cylynx - deepfake detection and identity verification
- Cyber Sierra - cyber risk management tools
- CloudsineAI - AI-driven security systems
- pQCee - protection against quantum decryption threats

- Privacy Ninja - tools for privacy and data governance

Opportunity Spaces

- Secure AI agents and autonomous systems
- Privacy-preserving machine learning
- Data infrastructure for large-scale AI
- AI-powered cybersecurity
- Tools that transform raw data into operational intelligence

Sector 02 - Finance

FinTech, Payments Infrastructure, and Digital Assets

Financial services are undergoing a structural transformation as technology reshapes how money moves across the global economy.

Traditional banking systems were designed decades ago and often struggle to support today's digital commerce and cross-border transactions. This has opened the door for fintech companies to build faster, cheaper, and more programmable financial infrastructure.

One major shift is the rise of global payment platforms. Companies like Airwallex, Stripe, and Wise are building modern financial infrastructure that allows businesses to move money across borders instantly and integrate financial services directly into digital platforms.

At the same time, blockchain technologies are redefining how value can be stored and transferred. Stablecoins, digital currencies backed by real-world assets, are emerging as a new financial infrastructure layer. Regulatory frameworks are beginning to formalise rules for stablecoin issuers, signalling increasing institutional adoption of digital assets.

Financial institutions are also experimenting with tokenised assets, where ownership of real-world assets such as bonds or stocks is represented digitally on blockchains, potentially enabling instant settlement and 24/7 markets.

At the same time, trust remains a critical issue. Financial fraud, scams, and cybercrime are rising globally, pushing banks and fintech companies to adopt AI-driven fraud detection and identity verification technologies.

Global Examples

- Stripe - developer-first payments infrastructure
- Airwallex - global financial operations platform
- PayPal - digital wallets and payments
- Chainalysis - blockchain analytics and compliance

- Revolut - digital banking platforms

Singapore Start-Up Examples

- Endowus - digital investment platform
- YouTrip - multi-currency travel wallet
- Aspire - finance platform for startups and SMEs
- Nium - global cross-border payment network
- Funding Societies - digital lending platform
- Bolttech - digital insurance platform
- Amber Group - crypto trading and infrastructure platform

Opportunity Spaces

- Cross-border payment infrastructure
- Embedded finance platforms
- Digital asset infrastructure and tokenization
- AI-powered fraud detection
- Financial tools for underserved populations

Sector 03 - Health & Wellness

Healthcare Innovation, Digital Health, and Mental Wellbeing

Healthcare systems worldwide are facing growing pressure from ageing populations, rising costs, and increasing demand for accessible and personalised care. At the same time, technological advances are transforming how healthcare is delivered.

One of the biggest shifts is the transition from reactive healthcare to preventive care. Instead of treating illnesses only after they appear, new technologies aim to detect risks earlier and support healthier lifestyles.

Digital health platforms, wearable devices, and AI diagnostics are enabling continuous monitoring of health conditions. Companies are exploring ways to combine data, AI, and clinical insights to deliver more personalised care.

Mental health is another rapidly growing focus area. Increasing awareness of emotional well-being, workplace stress, and social isolation has created demand for digital tools that support mental resilience and accessible mental health care.

However, healthcare innovation must navigate complex challenges, including patient privacy, regulatory approval, and clinical validation, which makes it one of the most demanding but impactful sectors for startups.

Global Examples

- Tempus - AI-driven precision medicine
- Headspace - digital mental health platforms
- 23andMe - consumer genomics
- Teladoc Health - telemedicine services

Singapore Start-Up Examples

- Doctor Anywhere - digital healthcare platform
- Homage - homecare platform for the elderly and patients
- Qritive - AI pathology diagnostics
- MiRXES - early cancer detection diagnostics
- Intellect - digital mental wellbeing platform
- Naluri - behavioural health and chronic disease management

Opportunity Spaces

- AI-assisted diagnostics
- Personalised health monitoring
- Mental health technology
- Preventive healthcare platforms
- Remote patient monitoring

Sector 04 - Sustainability

Climate Technology, Resource Systems, and Sustainable Cities

Climate change and environmental degradation are among the most urgent challenges facing the world today. Governments, corporations, and investors are increasingly prioritising sustainability as both a responsibility and a strategic opportunity.

The emergence of climate technology has created a rapidly growing startup ecosystem focused on reducing emissions, improving resource efficiency, and building more resilient systems.

Energy transition is one of the most important areas of innovation. As economies move away from fossil fuels toward renewable energy sources such as solar, wind, and hydrogen, new solutions are needed to manage energy storage, distribution, and grid stability.

At the same time, the growth of digital infrastructure itself has environmental consequences. The rapid expansion of AI and cloud computing has significantly increased electricity demand from data centres, which are becoming major energy consumers. This has created opportunities for innovations in efficient computing, cooling technologies, and renewable-powered infrastructure.

Cities are another key focus area. With the majority of the global population living in urban environments, sustainable solutions in transportation, waste management, water systems, and urban planning are becoming increasingly important.

Global Examples

- Tesla - electric mobility and energy storage
- Climeworks - carbon capture technology
- Impossible Foods - alternative protein
- Northvolt - sustainable battery manufacturing

Singapore Start-Up Examples

- Sunseap - solar energy infrastructure
- H3 Dynamics - hydrogen and energy systems
- GridMarket - AI energy management
- Ampd Energy - battery systems for construction
- Alterpacks - biodegradable packaging
- Igloo Energy - climate risk and insurance technology

Opportunity Spaces

- Carbon measurement and climate analytics
- Circular economy and waste reduction
- Sustainable energy infrastructure
- Climate adaptation technologies
- Sustainable urban systems

Sector 05 – Open Category

Interdisciplinary Innovation and Unconstrained Ideas

Not every meaningful idea fits neatly into a predefined category. Some of the most impactful startups are born at the intersection of multiple industries or emerge from entirely new problem spaces that do not align with existing sectors.

The Open Category exists to give teams the freedom to explore ideas beyond the four defined sectors of Data Tech, Finance, Health & Wellness, and Sustainability. If your problem statement addresses a significant real-world challenge but does not clearly belong to any single sector, this is the space for you.

This category encourages bold thinking and interdisciplinary approaches. Your idea may combine elements from multiple sectors, introduce a completely new technological application, or address social, cultural, educational, or community-based challenges that are often overlooked in traditional startup ecosystems.

However, while the category is open in scope, the expectations remain the same. Your problem must be clearly defined, grounded in real-world evidence, and demonstrate a meaningful gap in existing solutions. Teams should still identify a clear user group, validate the problem through research or interviews, and articulate why the problem is important to solve.

The goal of the Open Category is simple: **do not limit your thinking.** If you see a problem that matters and you can build a compelling solution around it, this is where it belongs.

Opportunity Spaces

- Interdisciplinary innovations spanning multiple sectors
- Consumer platforms solving everyday problems
- Education and learning technologies
- Community-driven platforms and social impact solutions
- New digital products, services, or marketplaces

Guidelines for Participants

Participants should identify a specific and meaningful problem within their chosen sector: Data Tech, Finance, Health & Wellness, Sustainability, or Open. The problem should be clearly defined and supported by evidence, such as user interviews, surveys, market research, or observable gaps in existing solutions.

Teams should demonstrate that the problem is significant, underserved, or poorly addressed by current products or services, and explain who experiences the problem and why it matters.

Participants are encouraged to validate their ideas through early user feedback or simple prototypes where possible.

Suggested Resources

- Y Combinator – Startup advice, idea validation, and founder insights
- The Lean Startup – Building startups through experimentation
- Industry reports, venture capital blogs, and startup ecosystem publications for market insights.

Good luck. Build something that matters.